“What not to say”

Part of the “Gen Z at Work” Workplace Navigation & Growth Toolkit

How to use this Cheat Sheet?

This cheat sheet is not about policing your words.
It is about **protecting your professional image**, especially early in your career.

Use this when:

- emotions are high
- you feel misunderstood
- you want growth but don’t want risk
- you’re unsure how something will be received

The goal is not silence.

The goal is **clear, neutral, outcome-focused communication**.

Write Notes

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When speaking to Managers?

❌ What Not to Say	✅ Say This Instead	Why this works?
“I was stressed.”	“I missed this earlier. I’ll correct it.”	Managers respond better to ownership than explanations.
“Others also made this mistake.”	“I understand the impact and will ensure it doesn’t repeat.”	Shifting blame reduces trust, even if it’s true.
“I didn’t know.”	“I missed this earlier. I’ll be more careful going forward.”	Responsibility builds credibility faster than honesty alone.
“That’s not how I was taught.”	“I’ll align with how this is done here.”	Context matters more than past experience early on.

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Workload, Pressure and Boundaries

❌ What Not to Say	✅ Say This Instead	Why this works?
“I’m overloaded / burnt out.”	“I want to prioritise this correctly. Can we align on urgency?”	It reframes stress as a planning conversation.
“I can’t do this right now.”	“I’ll pick this up first thing tomorrow.”	It sets a boundary without confrontation.
“Why am I always given this?”	“How should I balance this with my current priorities?”	One sounds emotional; the other sounds responsible.
“This is not my job.”	“I can support for now. How should we handle this going forward?”	It protects cooperation without setting a permanent precedent.

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Growth, Feedback & Career

❌ What Not to Say	✅ Say This Instead	Why this works?
“When will I get promoted?”	“What skills should I focus on to grow in this role?”	Growth-first framing builds trust; title-first framing creates pressure.
“I deserve more responsibility.”	“I’d be happy to take on more responsibility if you think I’m ready.”	Readiness signals maturity; entitlement creates resistance.
“I feel stuck.”	“I’d appreciate feedback on how I can progress further.”	One sounds frustrated; the other sounds proactive.

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Politics, Group Settings & Daily Interactions

❌ What Not to Say	✅ Safer Option	Why this works?
“Did you hear what happened with…?”	*(Say nothing.)*	Gossip damages credibility faster than mistakes.
“That person is very difficult.”	“I’m still understanding different working styles.”	Neutral language protects your professional image.
“This is unfair.”	“Could you help me understand the reasoning?”	Curiosity keeps conversations open.
“This doesn’t make sense.”	“Could you walk me through the thinking?”	Respectful questions get better answers.

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How this fits the Toolkit?

This cheat sheet is a **filter**, not a rulebook.

Early in your career:

- clarity beats emotional honesty
- calm beats intensity
- timing beats intelligence

As credibility grows, your freedom increases.

Use this alongside:

- **Core Toolkit** → how to navigate
- **Employee Script Handout** → what to say
- **Workplace Reality Cheat Sheet** → how the system works

Guidance on Application & Judgement

The examples and alternatives in this product are **general professional guidance**, not rigid rules.

Workplaces vary in:

- culture
- leadership style
- communication norms
- expectations

Use your **judgment** when applying these suggestions.

This toolkit:

- does not encourage silence or suppression
- does not replace organisational policies
- does not offer legal or HR or People & Culture advice

Its purpose is to help you:

- communicate thoughtfully
- protect your professional image
- reduce unnecessary misunderstandings
- build credibility early in your career

As your experience, confidence, and trust increases, your communication style will naturally evolve.

This guidance is intended to **support you during the early stages of your professional journey**, where clarity and caution are especially valuable.